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Newsom signs redistricting bills, takes fight over congressional map to voters

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Gov. Gavin Newsom (D-CA) signed two redistricting bills Thursday to redraw a new congressional map for California to counter a similar GOP-led attempt in Texas.

The governor declared a special election on Nov. 4, asking voters to grant final approval to the new map, which would help Democrats win five more House seats in the 2026 midterm elections. The plan was passed earlier in the day in both chambers of the state legislature.

"We're responding to what occurred in Texas," Newsom said. "We're neutralizing what occurred, and we're giving the American people a fair chance because when all things are equal, we're all playing by the same rules."

Republican lawmakers tried several parliamentary maneuvers to delay the vote, but were unsuccessful. They have called for a federal investigation and promised to keep fighting.

"I am proud of this chamber, proud of my colleagues, for meeting this moment with courage," Democratic Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas said. "President [Donald] Trump wants us to be intimidated, and his playbook is a simple one. Bully, threaten, silence, then rig the rules to hang on to power."

Democratic Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel likened Trump's push to get more seats to that of a 5-year-old losing a game and demanding the rules change.

"That is transparently what is happening with this president," Gabriel said. "[Trump] understands that his policies are not popular, he understands that people do not want him to be able to continue to be unchecked in Washington, and so rather than change his policies or play by the rules, he's trying to change the rules."

Gabriel said his Republican colleagues have suggested Democrats turn a blind eye, but added that "there are deep moral implications to that unilateral surrender."

Democratic Assemblywoman Rhodesia Ransom argued that lawmakers in California are not "forcing" a new map on voters but said, "We can't be bystanders when bullies come to push us around."

"We're not forcing anything down anyone's throat," she said. "We're giving Californians a choice. Do you want to bow down or do you want to fight back?"

Republican Assemblywoman Laurie Davies said she believed the money that would go toward a special election would be better spent on fixing the state's current insurance crisis or giving first responders pay raises.

GOP Assemblyman David Tangipa said the Democratic push to redraw the map was "neither bold nor principled."

"It is, in plain terms, a blatant attack on the most transparent process our state has ever had for drawing congressional districts," he said. "It undermines what has become the gold standard for the nation, the independent Citizens Redistricting Commission."

Unlike Texas, where state lawmakers have control over drawing the state's congressional map, California's process is more complicated. Its constitution requires that an independent redistricting commission draw the map and that voters approve any changes. That means even though the state legislature passed the proposed map, it will now be up to the voters in California to decide during a Nov. 4 special election whether the map will be used for the

2026, 2028, and 2030 elections.

If voters greenlight them, it would turn three Republican-held seats into safe Democratic seats and turn two others into seats that lean Democratic.

The map would change districts held by Reps. Kevin Kiley (R-CA) and Doug LaMalfa (R-CA) in Northern California. In the southern part of the state, Reps. Darrell Issa (R-CA) and Ken Calvert (R-CA) are at risk, and in the Central Valley, Rep. David Valadao (R-CA) would have a much harder time getting reelected.

The coast-to-coast redistricting fight erupted after Trump publicly called on Texas to redraw its map to give Republicans a five-seat boost heading into the 2026 midterm elections. California called its push for a new map a countermeasure to "neutralize" the pressure Trump put not only on Texas Republicans but also on lawmakers in other red states, including Florida, Ohio, and Indiana, to follow suit. On Thursday morning, Trump announced on social media that Republicans in Missouri had also agreed to redraw their map, writing, "We're going to win the Midterms in Missouri again, bigger and better than ever before!"

Democrats in Illinois and Maryland have pledged to fight back. However, it's harder in the blue states because most have commission systems like California or other imposed redistricting rules, giving Republicans the edge in easily changing their map.

New York, for example, has floated the idea of changing its map, but can't legally redraw it until 2028, two years after the midterm elections, and even then, only with voter approval.

In Texas, the governor's signature is all that's needed after the map passes the state legislature.

At stake is control of the U.S. House of Representatives. Republicans have a seven-seat edge in the House, with four vacancies.

Trump has been able to enact his agenda, including passing the One Big Beautiful Bill Act, because the GOP controls the White House and both chambers of Congress. If Democrats flip the House, they could render Trump a lame duck during his last two years in office by blocking his legislation and launching congressional investigations.

Democrats have said stopping Trump is their No. 1 priority, and the party has turned to Newsom, Sen. Cory Booker (D-NJ), and Texas Rep. Nicole Collier (D-TX) to lead the cause.

WHO WINS AND LOSES IF EVERY STATE GETS ITS WAY ON REDISTRICTING?

Democratic National Committee Chairman Ken Martin said Thursday evening that the DNC "stands with Gov. Newsom and the California legislature in putting the power in the hands of the people of California."

"Every Californian should vote for Democrats' measure to level the playing field," he added. "This isn't just about California. The basic premise of Americans — instead of Donald Trump — choosing their elected officials is at stake."

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